



Learning Beyond Campus

In a shrinking economy where administrators must find ways to meet unfunded legislative mandates, tele-education and distance learning are shaping as an obvious answer. Institutions and students around the world are benefiting from technologies like telepresence and high-definition video conferencing

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Tele-education is even more relevant for countries like India, which are not only widely dispersed geographically but also have a huge education divide. While majority of our population lives in smaller cities and towns, majority of education institutes and experts are located in the metros.

Telepresence and video conferencing help education institutions to efficiently deliver dynamic content, attract a wider range of students across boundaries, and enable academics to collaborate with peers worldwide. Many educational institutes around the world, like the elaborate set-up at The Georgetown University, Washington DC, are leveraging these collaboration solutions.

Georgetown University in Washington, DC, is pioneering state-of-the-art telepresence technology to extend its educational reach and bring communities of students and teachers closer together. In 2007, the university decided to pilot-test a 'global classroom' using telepresence technology. Having recently opened the School of Foreign Service in Qatar (SFS-Qatar), the chief information officer at SFS-Qatar, Jonathon Chapman, said, "We were looking for a telepresence solution that would provide a realistic classroom environment with camera technology capable of changing focus on students when they asked questions and display digital content to all participants with the least amount of intervention." Thus Georgetown was able to link two campuses on two different continents in two different time zones and



create one realistic classroom experience. The implementation has been so successful that the university is currently evaluating ways to expand the use of the system for additional courses, as well as student meetings and more.

Another interesting example is the case of Duke University Fuqua School of Business which partners with universities and companies around the globe to support its management education programmes and uses immersive telepresence for meetings whenever possible.

"Many companies come directly to the campus to recruit, but for companies that can't and are interested in a Fuqua candidate, they can conduct interviews over video," says Tim Searles, Fuqua's director for multimedia services. "As a reflection of our global focus, the availability of video also benefits students who are interviewing with companies in other countries," he adds.

The fact that the Polycom RPX systems are standards-based, has been important to the school. While the tele-

presence technology is comparatively new, Duke University is able to connect with companies and universities that have traditional conference room systems.

Indian scenario

In India, the adoption is showing an up-trend. There are many education pioneers in India that are widely leveraging the visual collaboration technologies in India. Maharashtra Knowledge Corporation Limited's (MKCL) distance-learning network is India's largest video conferencing system enabling remotely-located students to enjoy the same educational experience and opportunities as their on-campus urban peers. The expansive video conferencing system has enabled the institute to reach out to hundreds of students across Maharashtra state—regardless of their location.

Telepresence/video conferencing solution recreates the feel of a classroom and helps the university to extend its resources while reaching out to newer audience—all without raising its carbon footprint. ■